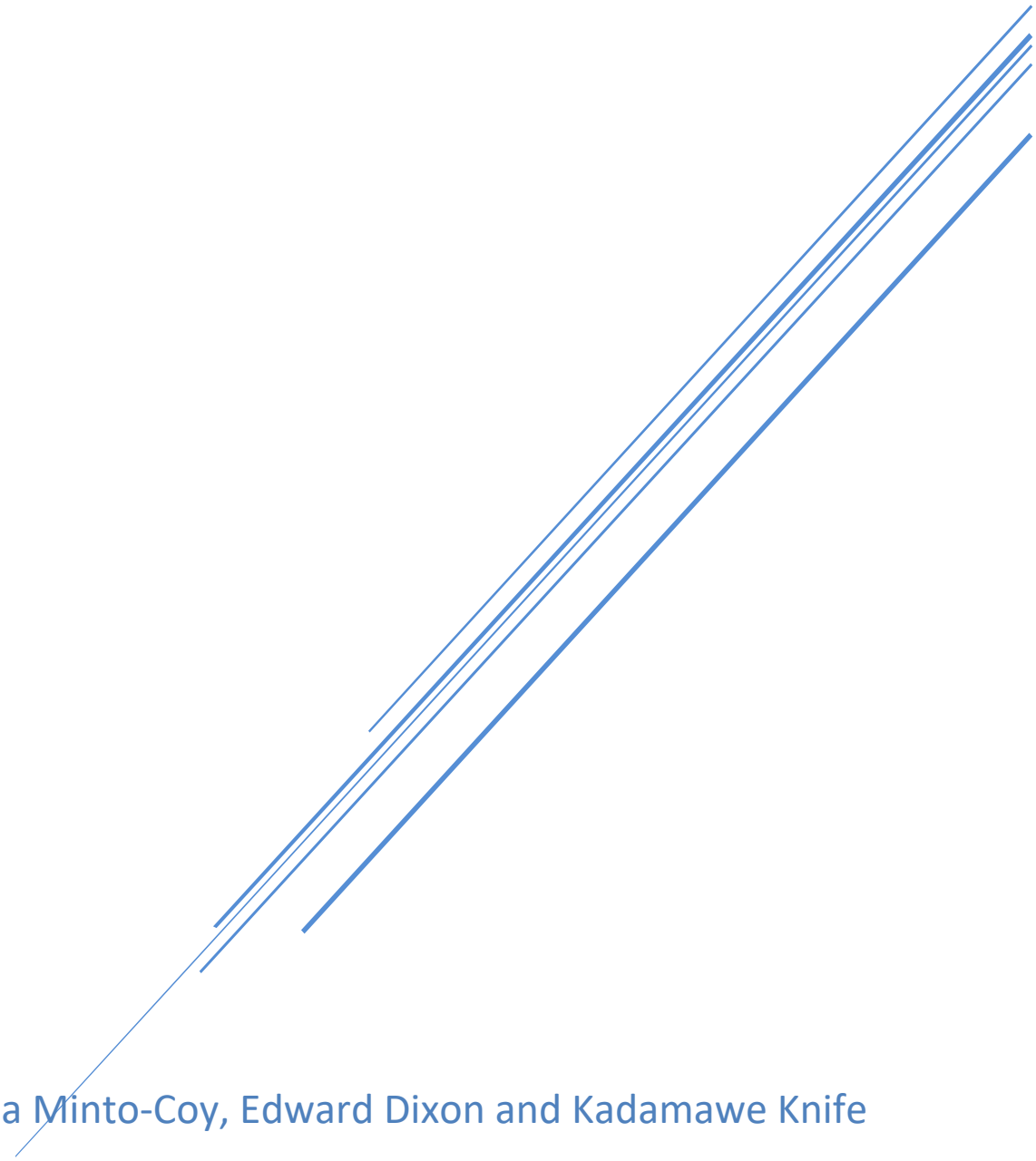
GLOBAL UNIVERSITY ENTREPRENEURIAL SPIRIT STUDENTS' SURVEY (GUESSS)– CARIBBEAN REPORT 2025



Indianna Minto-Coy, Edward Dixon and Kadamawe Knife

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About GUESSS

The Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey (GUESSS) is an international research project, part of a consortium focusing on the entrepreneurial activities of university students. The GUESSS initiative is jointly coordinated by the University of St. Gallen and the University of Bern in Switzerland.

Empasis is placed on career choices, family business succession, entrepreneurial intentions and activities, as well as, on the university and national environment. The main objective of GUESSS is to surface new knowledge on student entrepreneurship in the form of academic and practice-oriented results.

Launched in 2003 through an international online data collection process, the Survey is repeated every two to three years. This the 11th data collection exercise since inception, took place in 2025. For the first time GUESSS features a number of Caribbean countries, including those represented in the present report, among the total 66 countries and over 196,000 respondents worldwide (Sieger et al., 2026).

The study is based on a centrally managed online survey that uses validated measurement instruments. The questionnaire covers several dimensions and is aimed at both students who are considering becoming entrepreneurs and those who already are (or are in the process of becoming) entrepreneurs.

The research team is led by Dr. Edward Dixon from the University of the West Indies, Five Islands Campus in Antigua and Barbuda and Dr. Indianna Minto-Coy from the University of the West Indies, Mona Campus in Jamaica, with assistance from Dr. K'adamawe Knife from the University of the West Indies, Mona Campus in Jamaica.

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Introduction

Aim and purpose of the report

Despite the increasing global emphasis on entrepreneurship development, country and region-specific research on entrepreneurship and entrepreneurship education in the Caribbean remains limited.

There is consensus on the role of higher education institutions in developing high-growth, sustainable enterprise through their role as ecosystem actors and as testing grounds for ideas. In response, the last 2 decades have seen universities in the Caribbean establishing courses and training programmes in entrepreneurship. These are supported by a host of short courses and support offered by national institutions. This complex mix of formal and informal education and training, ecosystem support and networking opportunities (Minto-Coy, 2023) are critical components that encourage students to convert their ideas into viable businesses.

This report explores the entrepreneurial intentions of university students in the Caribbean based on data from the Global University Entrepreneurial Spirit Students' Survey (GUESSS). This international project, carried out in 2025, had a total of 196,162 completed responses from 66 countries. This report will focus on the Caribbean segment, which mobilised participation from four university campus sites in Jamaica and Antigua and Barbuda. A total of 558 completed responses were obtained.

What remains missing are assessments of the efforts over the years. Cross-national data on entrepreneurial education and prospects among Caribbean students, as with other areas in the field of entrepreneurship, largely remains a gray area in the literature (Minto-Coy, 2023). As an inaugural report, the focus on capturing raw data in the first instance is essential to understanding the current landscape across the Caribbean. As such, these findings will be foundational in shaping future research, practice and general understanding on entrepreneurship education and prospects among students across the region. The foundation is therefore, now laid for future longitudinal studies and assessments.

Demographic information about the sample

The GUESSS survey in the Caribbean (inclusive of Jamaica and Antigua and Barbuda) involved 558 university students. Many of the respondents were women, representing 68.1% of the sample. This distribution accurately reflects the participation of women in higher education institutions in the Caribbean, particularly the University of the West Indies, where they outnumber their male counterparts by a ratio of approximately 4:1. Additionally, more than three-quarters of our sample comprises students born since 2001.

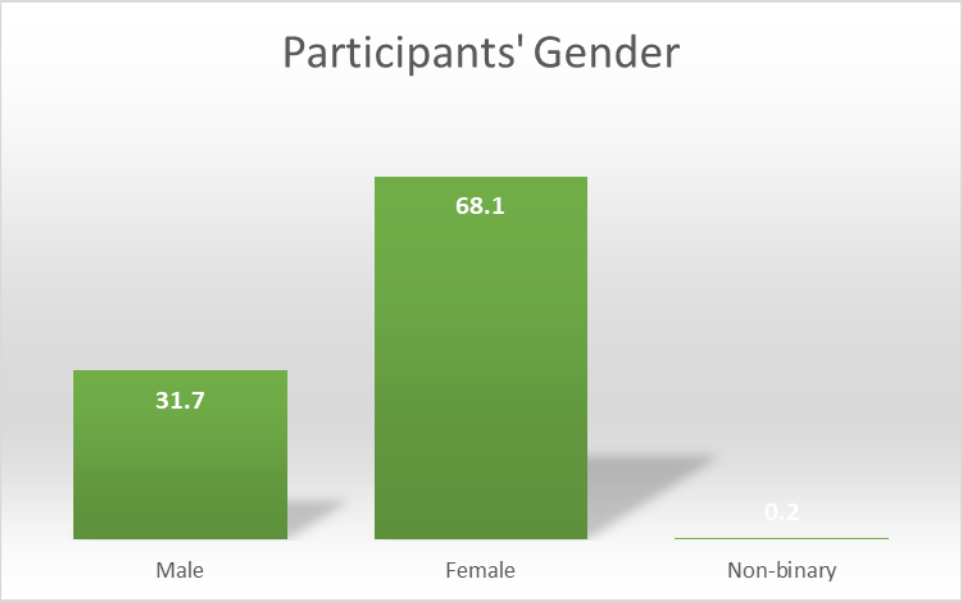


Figure 1 Sample distribution by gender

The breakdown of students by nationality highlights the predominance of Jamaican (76.7%), and Antiguan and Barbudan students (18.7%). Given the nature of the University of the West Indies as a network of universities representing the breadth of the English-speaking Caribbean, the institutions surveyed also included five other Caribbean nationals.

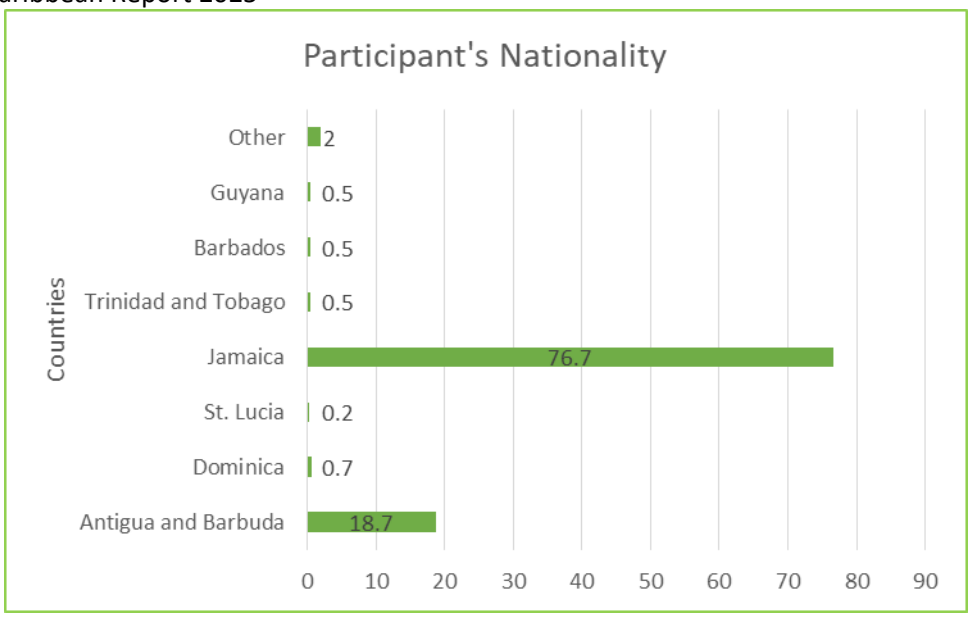


Figure 2 Sample distribution by nationality

This reflects the fact that the students surveyed were from campuses in Jamaica and Antigua. Additionally, the majority of the students were from the University of the West Indies' Mona Campus (74.2%), Five Islands Campus (22.2%) and Western Jamaica Campus (2.2%). There was also representation from the University of Technology (1.3%). The University of the West Indies network of institutions across the Caribbean represents the dominant higher education institution across the English-speaking Caribbean, stretching from the Bahamas to Belize. It therefore,

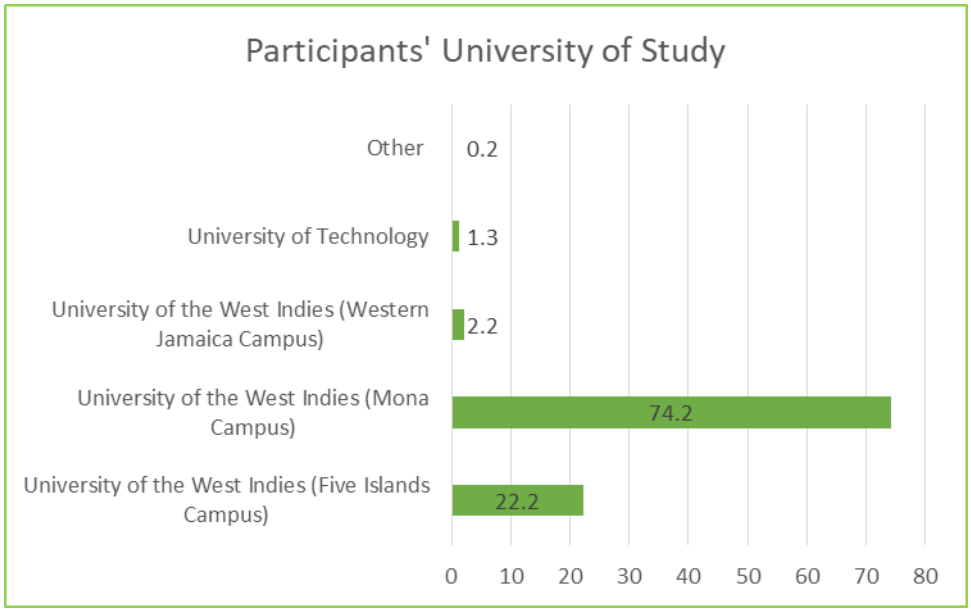


Figure 3 Sample distribution by university of study

Students were asked to indicate their level of study. The sample is predominantly comprised of undergraduates, notably bachelor's (89.4%), followed by graduate (Masters) degrees (9.2%). Other study programmes (MBA) (0.9%) and terminal degrees (0.5%) completed the total numbr respondents.

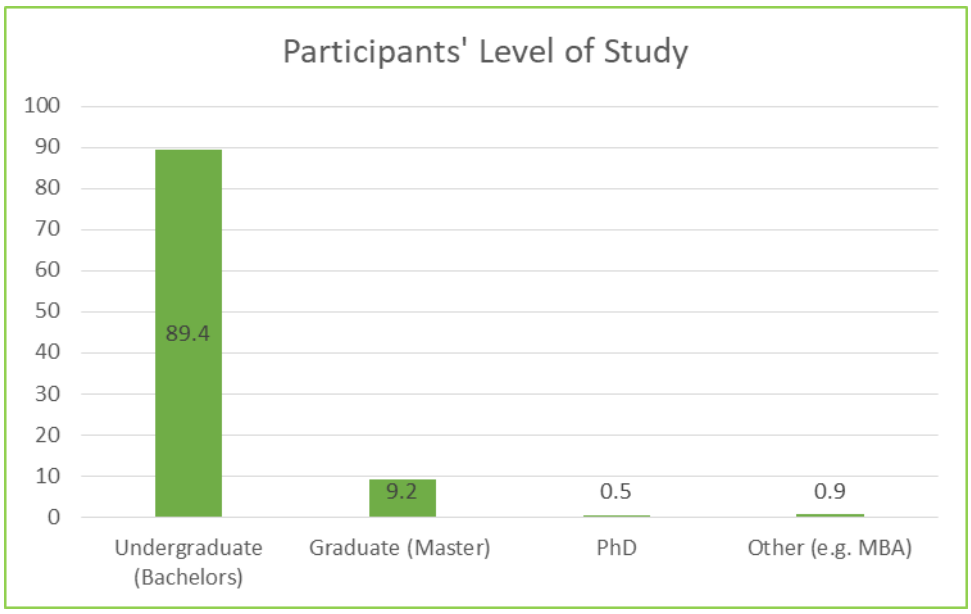


Figure 4 Sample distribution by level of study

Most of the students in our sample were pursuing programmes in business administration/management (48.4%), followed by social sciences (e.g. Psychology and Politics) (20.1%), and other category (12.7%).

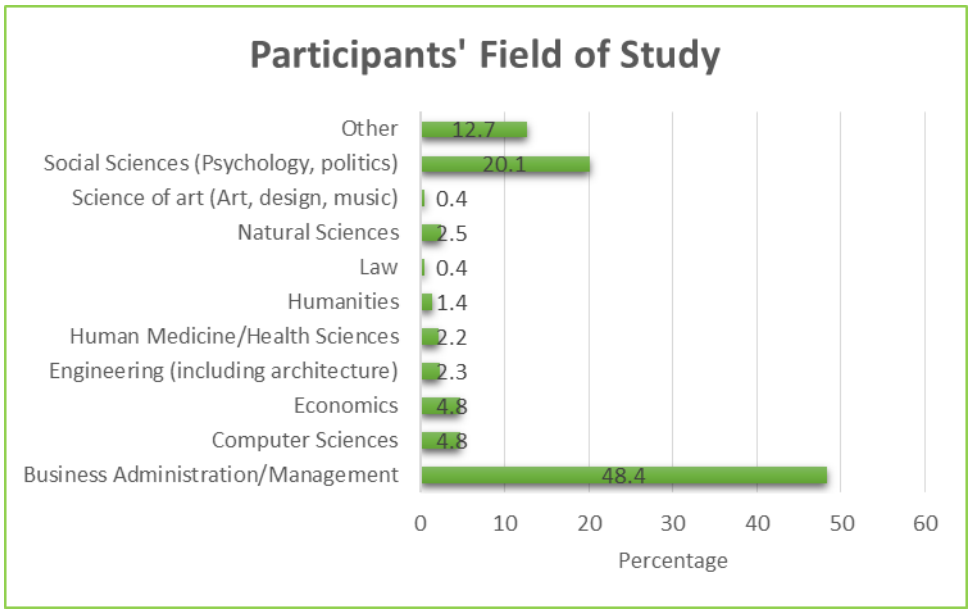


Figure 5 Sample distribution by field of study

Career choices or entrepreneurial intentions

A comparison of students' career choices immediately preceding graduation and five years, thereafter shows a greater desire to become an entrepreneur in later years. The attractiveness of self-employment is greater after five years when compared to immediately after graduation, with the desire to achieve self-employment almost doubling between the periods from 31.2% to 55%.

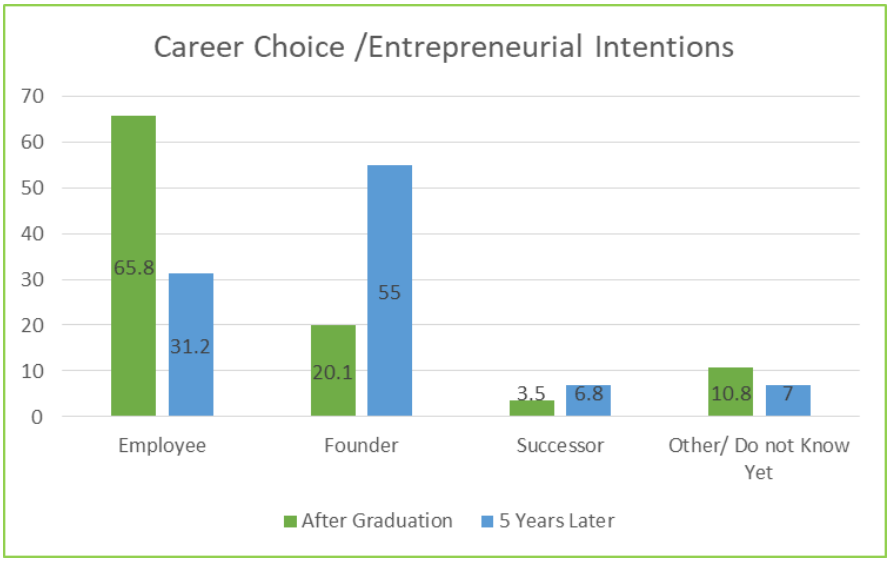


Figure 6 Career choices immediately after graduation and five years from now

A comparison of career choices by gender reveals that a larger percentage of women (45.6%) and men (20%) preferred to work for someone else immediately after graduation. However, when the five years after graduation figures were examined, there was a significant increase in the number of women who would choose self-employment (36.4%) compared with immediately after graduation (12.9%).

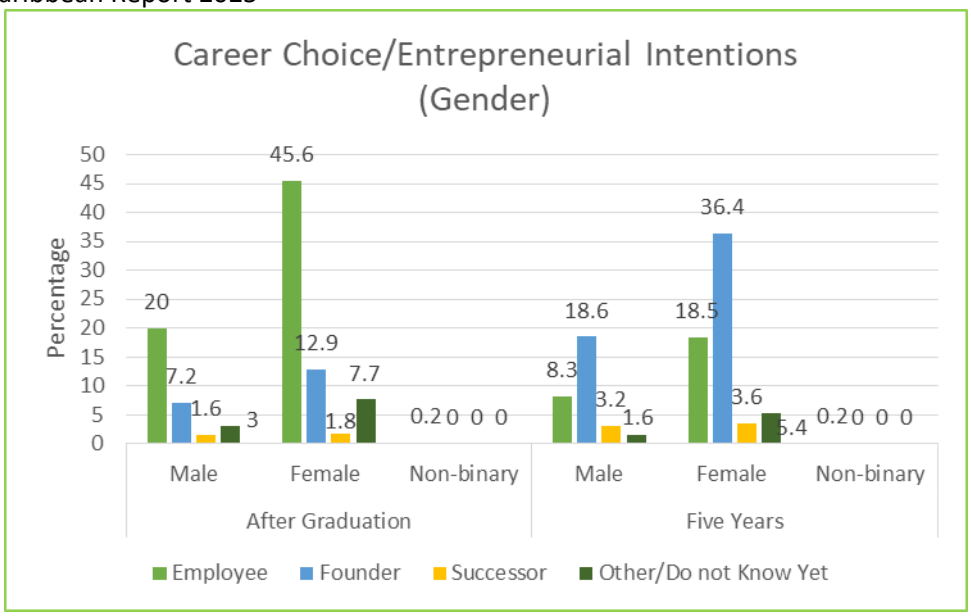


Figure 7 Career choices immediately after graduation and five years from now, by gender

Drivers of entrepreneurial intentions

University Context

As part of the GUESSS survey, students were asked about their perceptions of the university environment regarding their support for entrepreneurship.

The results show that, on average, students rated the university comparatively higher on its ability to create an environment conducive to engaging in entrepreneurial activities (4.79 out of a maximum of 7) and the ease of getting entrepreneurship–related advice and guidance (4.7).

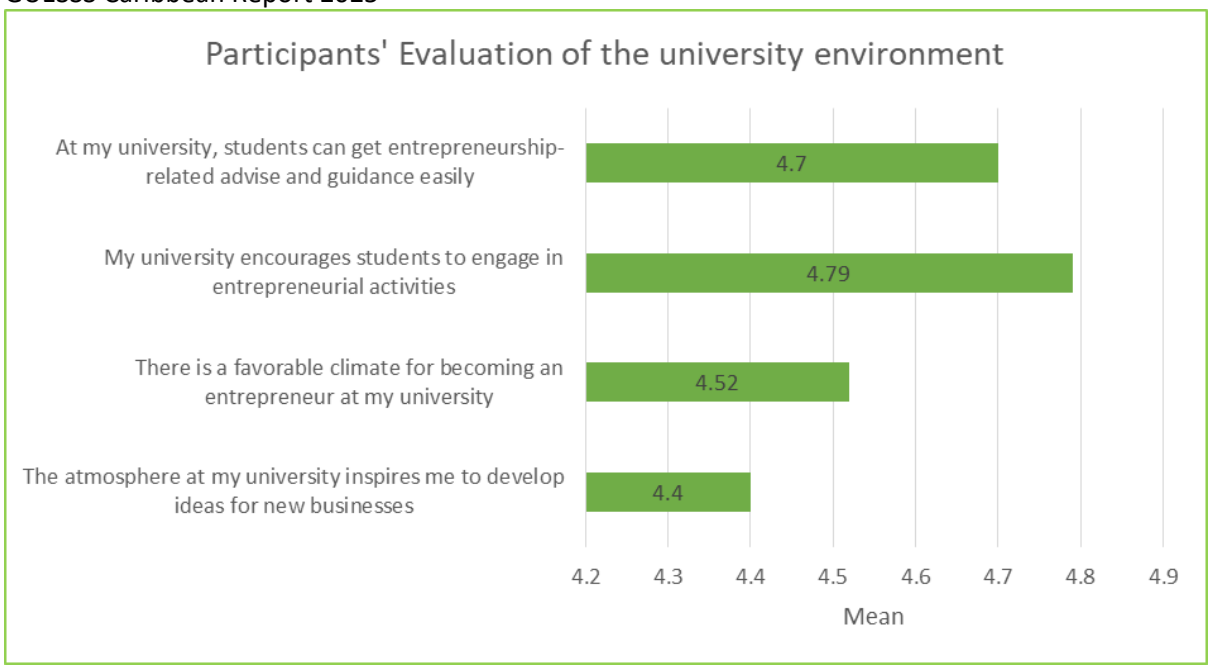


Figure 8 Participants' evaluation of the university environment (Mean)

Many of the students indicated that they have not yet taken an entrepreneurship course (64.5%), with many of those being women (42.8%), and men accounting for 21.5%. Of those who have taken a course, 29% of the women indicated that they have attended at least one entrepreneurship course as an elective, when compared to men (12.3%).

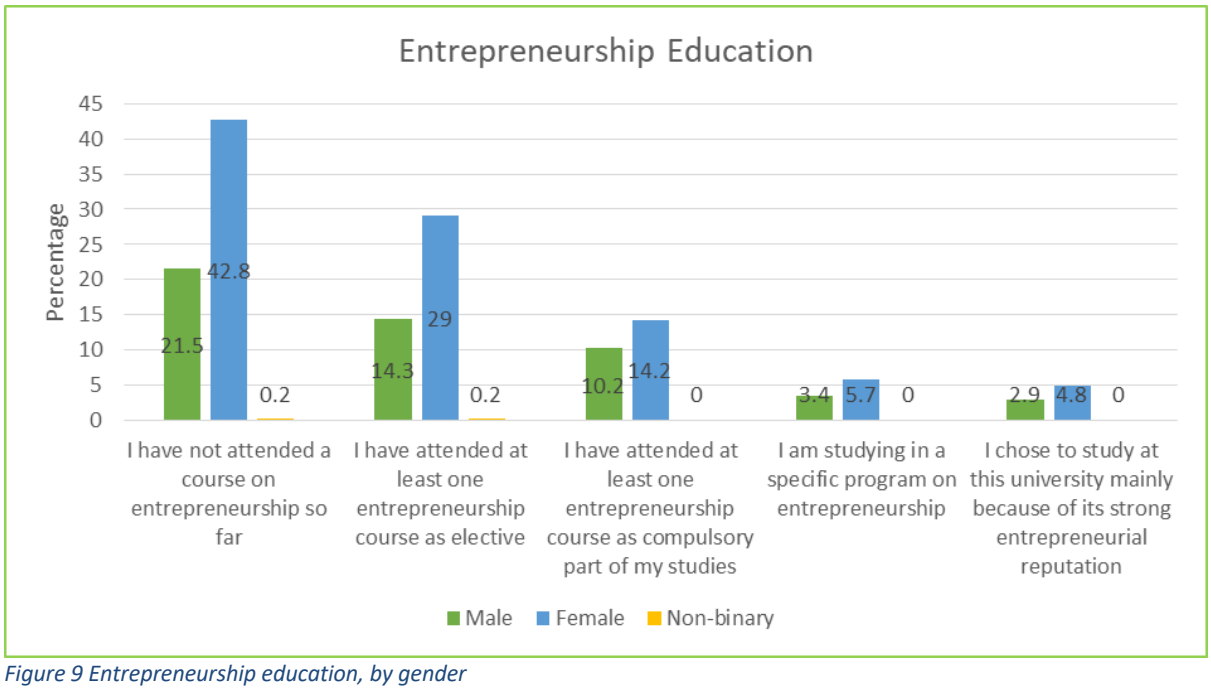


Figure 9 Entrepreneurship education, by gender

Students also rated their university entrepreneurship education courses and events. Their understanding of the actions required to start a business (5.25 out of 7) and attitudes, values, and motivations of entrepreneurs (5.04 out of 7) figured prominently in their responses.

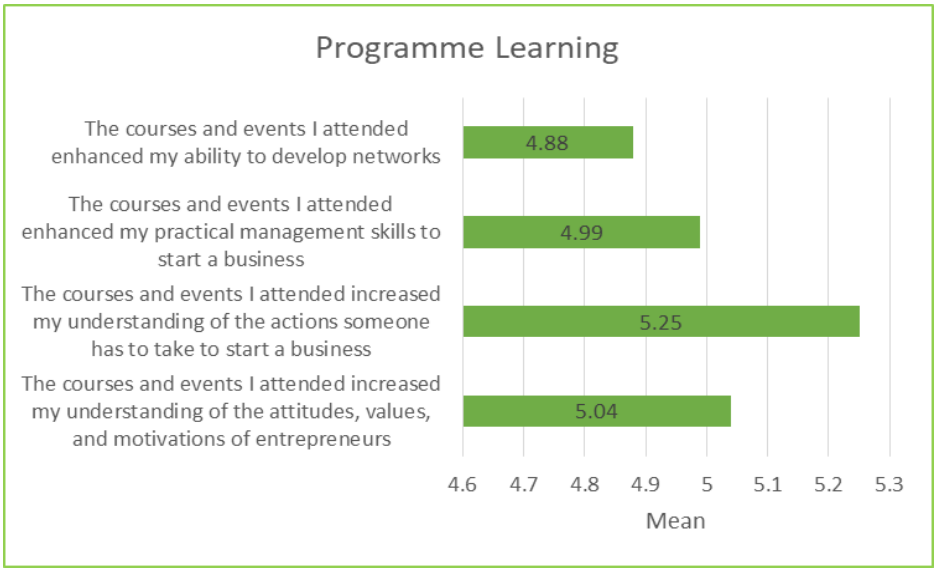


Figure 10 Programme learning (Mean)

Family Background

Most students (58.2%) reported that their parents did not own or manage a business or were self-employed. Of those students who did, 18.1% of the students indicated that their father, 13.1% their mother, and 10.6% that both parents owned or managed a business or were self-employed.

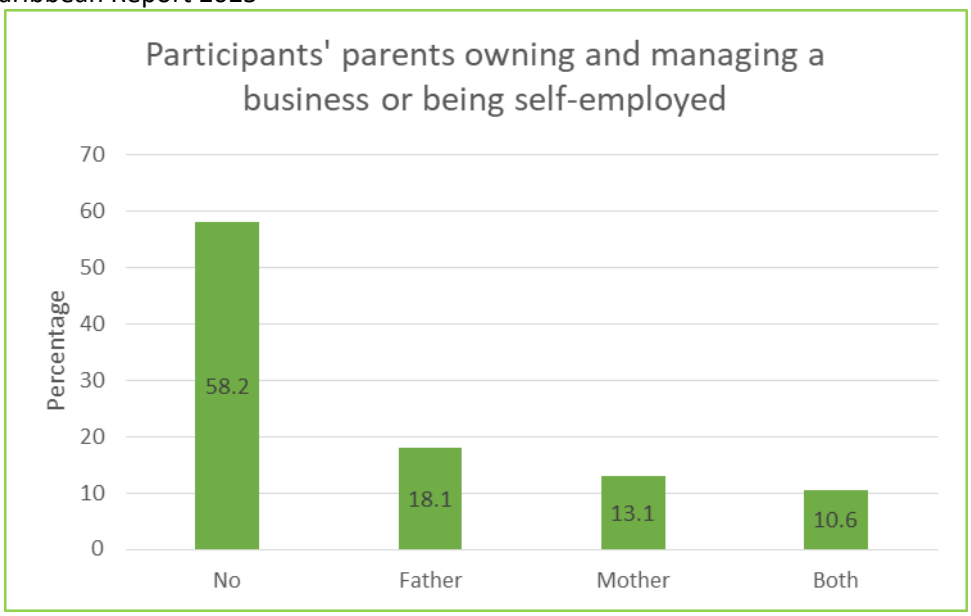


Figure 11 Participants' parents owning and managing a business or being self-employed

Share of Active and Nascent Entrepreneurs

The share of active entrepreneurs in the Caribbean (11.8%) was lower than that of the global survey (16.5%). By comparison, the share of the nascent entrepreneurs (11.8%) was higher than the global survey (6.4%).

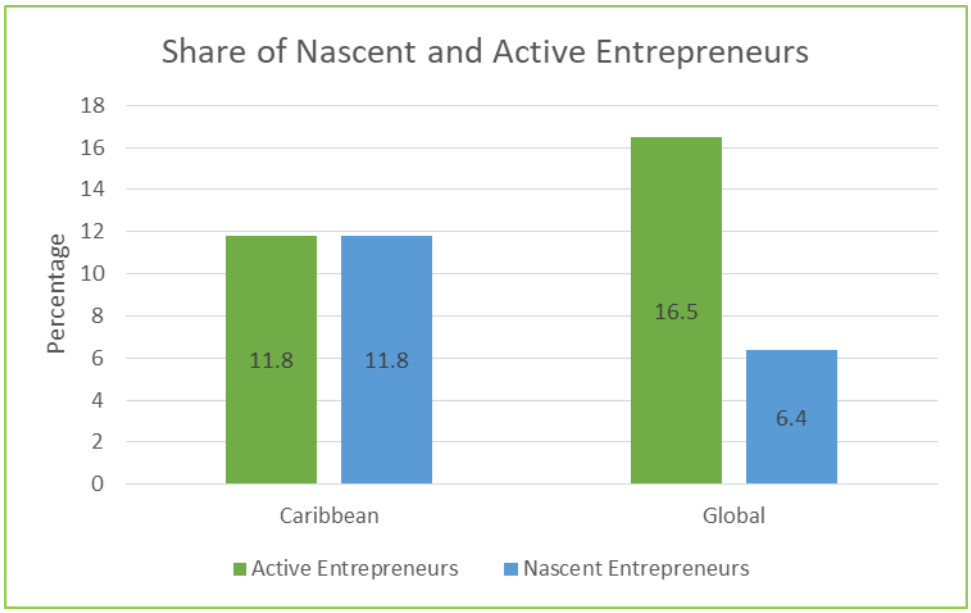


Figure 12 Share of nascent and active entrepreneurs

Active Entrepreneurs

Of those who identified as active entrepreneurs in the Caribbean, a higher percentage (25%) currently own or manage two businesses or are self-employed compared with the global survey (15.4%).

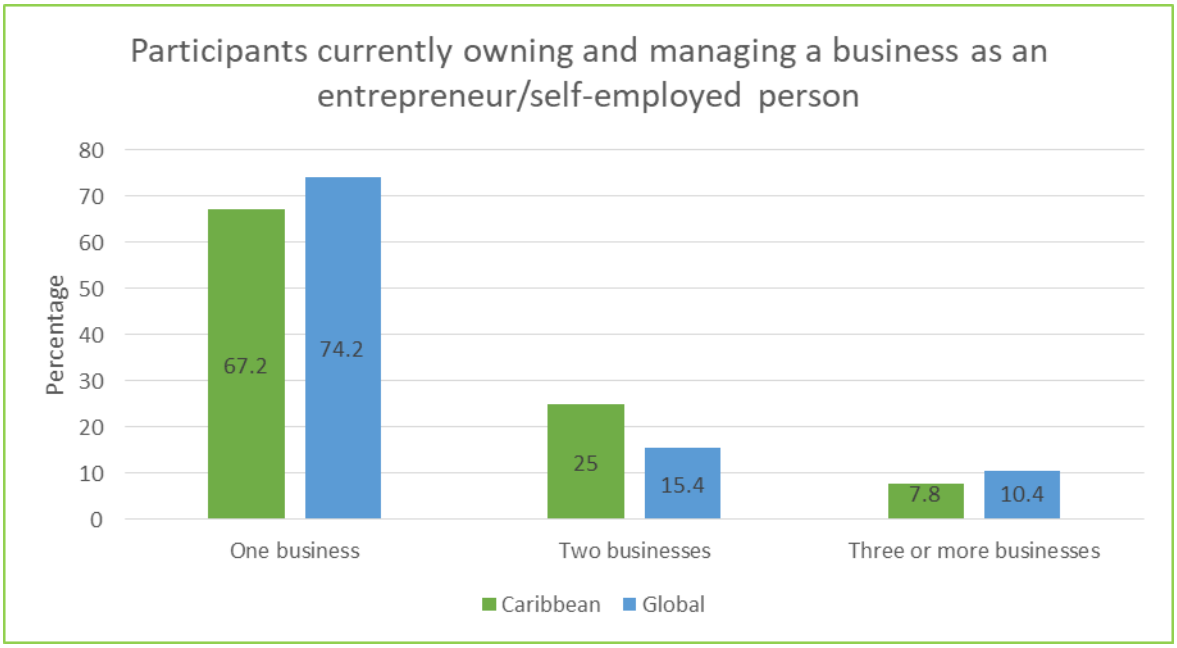


Figure 13 Participants currently owning and managing a business as an entrepreneur or self-employed person

50.1 percent of the active entrepreneurs in the Caribbean indicated that their business was established in 2023 or later. A further 28.2% of the businesses were established between 2019 and 2022.

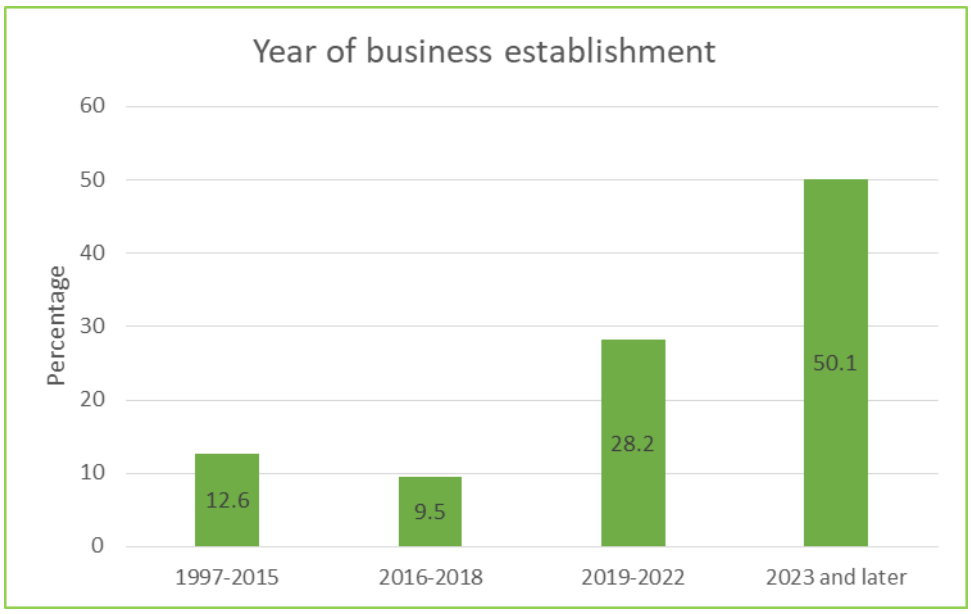


Figure 14 Year of business establishment

Most of the businesses, operated by entrepreneurs, were formally or officially registered (56.2%) compared with those that were not (43.8%). This figure still represents a high but not unusual figure for the Caribbean context (see Minto-Coy, Lashley and Storey, 2018; ILO 2017; Peters, 2017). This was especially the case for those considered Micro Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs).

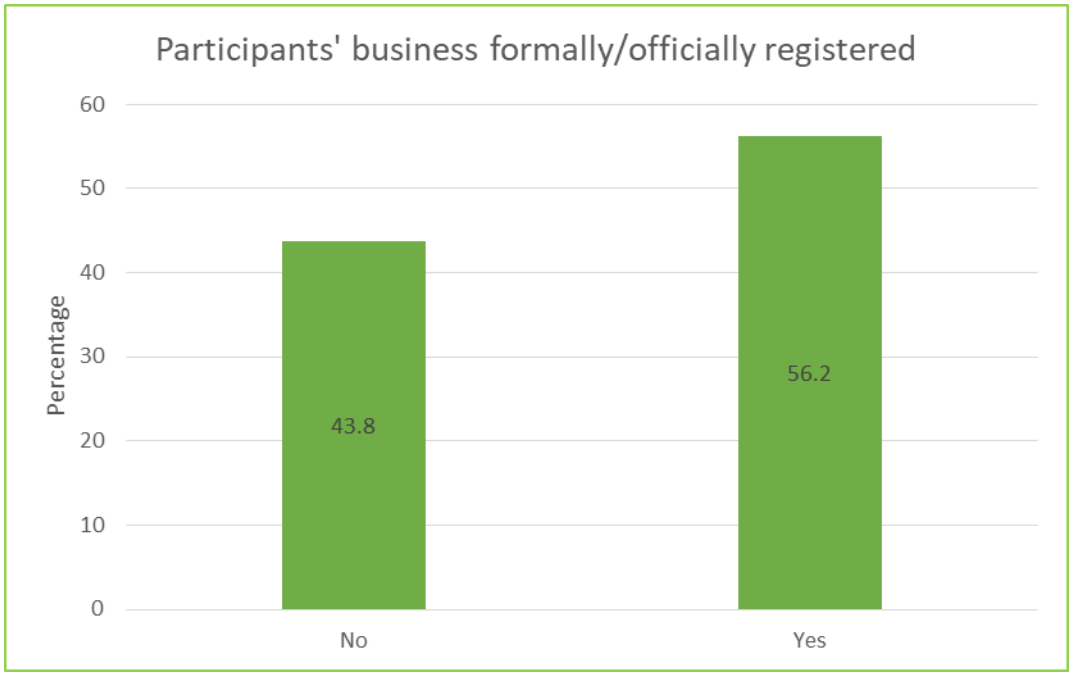


Figure 15 Participants' business registration status

When asked about the main industry or sector of the businesses, the participants mentioned other (40.9%), orange economy (24.2%), red (10.6%), rural (7.6%) and yellow (6.1%) as the main economies of the businesses.

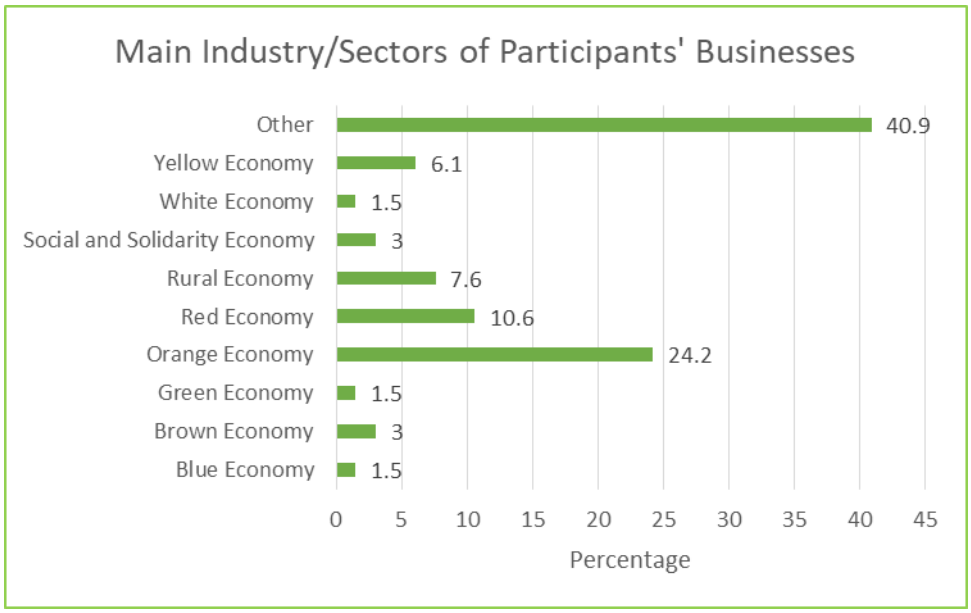


Figure 16 Main industry or sector of participants' business

Most businesses operated by active entrepreneurs reported having between 1 and 4 full-time equivalent employees. Of the percentage, 39.7% reported having one employee, and 31.8% reported having between two and four full-time equivalent employees (31.8%). Additionally, 12.7% reported having no employees, and 1.6% had ten or more employees.

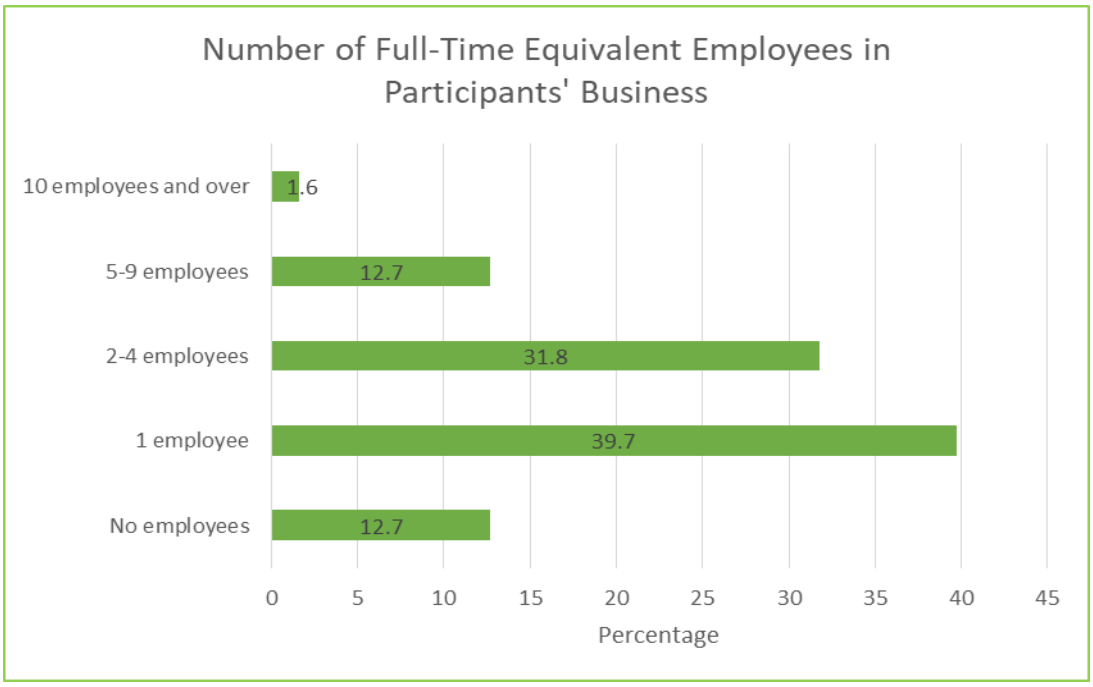


Figure 17 Number of full-time equivalent employees in participants' business

A large percentage of businesses reported majority ownership (71.9%), 17.2% reported an equal share, and 10.9% were minority shareholders.

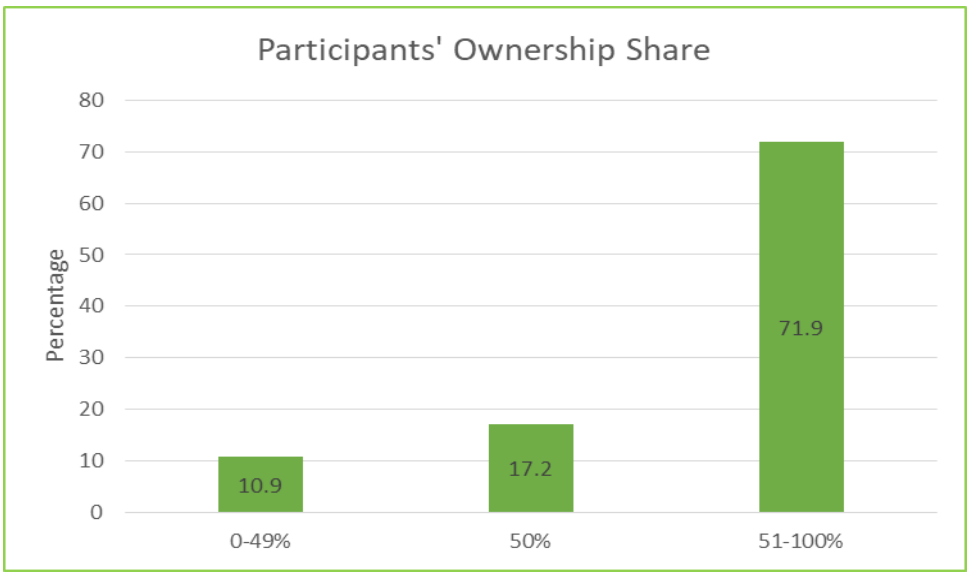


Figure 18 Participants' ownership share

Most of the active entrepreneurs reported having no co-founders (65.1%). Another quarter (25.4%) reported having one co-founder, while another 7.9% reported having two co-founders.

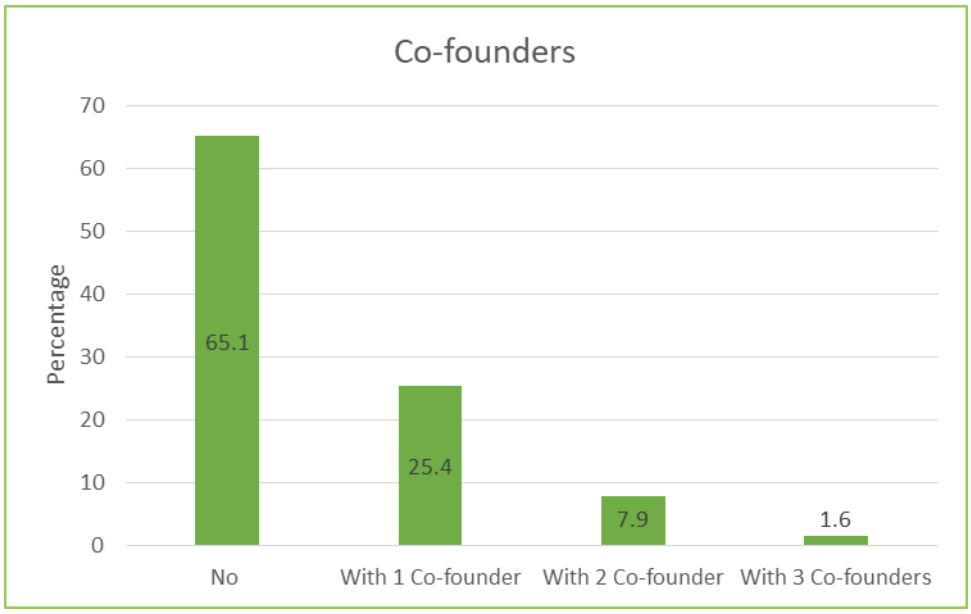


Figure 19 Co-founders in participants' business

The entrepreneurs reported that the degree of change since establishment has been little to moderate, with only about a quarter (26.6%) reporting significant changes.

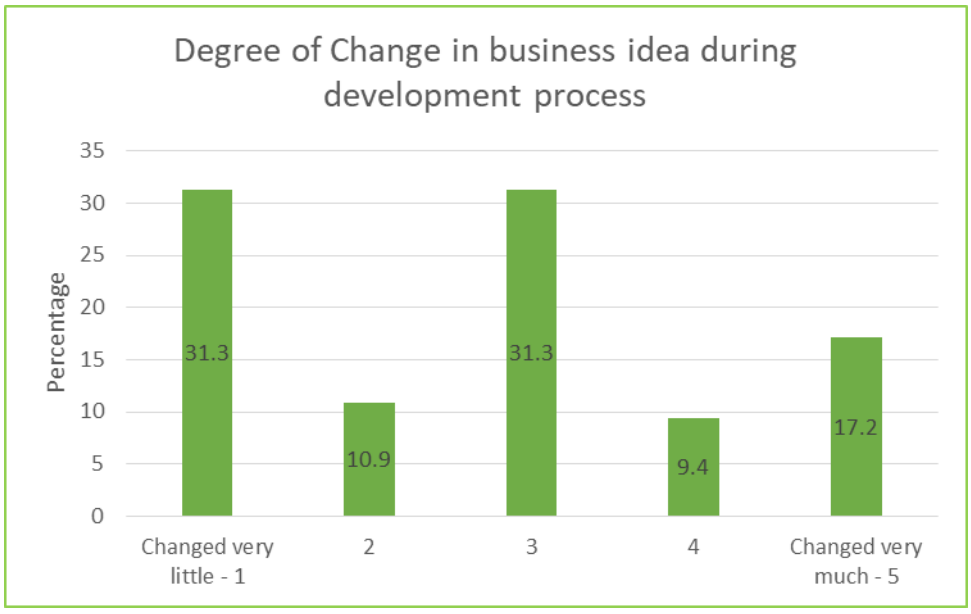


Figure 20 Degree of change in participants' business idea

Consistent with the previous finding, when the active entrepreneurs were asked how many times the business had changed or pivoted, only 13.8% reported multiple changes or pivots.

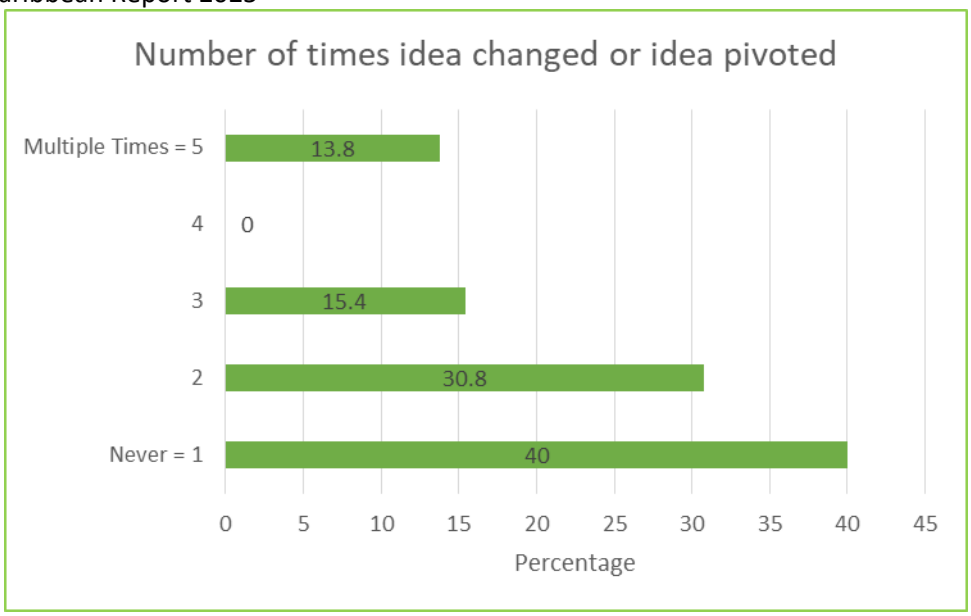


Figure 21 Number of times participants' business idea changed or pivoted

Interestingly, 63.1% of the active businesses reported having a prior business that was no longer active. On the other hand, 27.7% reported having one prior business venture that was no longer active, and 9.2% reported having two or more.

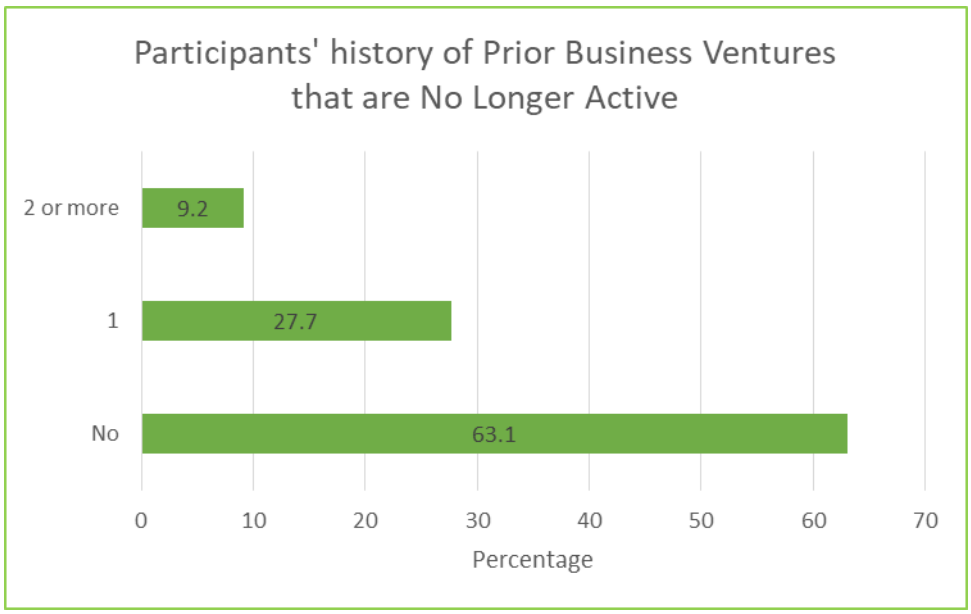


Figure 22 Participants' history of past failed business ventures

The study also aimed to capture the challenges of student entrepreneurs, their 'fear of failure', by asking them to indicate the extent to which they have been afraid of several issues over the

past few months (1 = not at all afraid, 7= very much afraid). The Caribbean student entrepreneurs reported, on average, lower levels of fear when compared to the global averages in all but the fear of not getting enough money to propel the business forward.



Figure 23 Active entrepreneur's fear of failure (Mean)

Relatedly, we asked them to assess the performance of their business compared to its competitors since its establishment in terms of sales growth, market share growth, profit growth, job creation and innovativeness (Dess & Robinson, 1984). The overall assessment of Caribbean active entrepreneurs was about the global average of 4.61 across all categories except for job creation, which had an average score of 3.35.



Figure 24 Participants' perception of firm performance (Mean)

Nascent Entrepreneurs

In exploring the entrepreneurial intentions of nascent entrepreneurs, there was a strong moderate or medium level of agreement that there was some intention, serious thought or determination towards starting a business in the future. The responses ranged, on average, between 4.24 and 5.15, on a scale of 1= strongly disagree to 7= strongly agree.

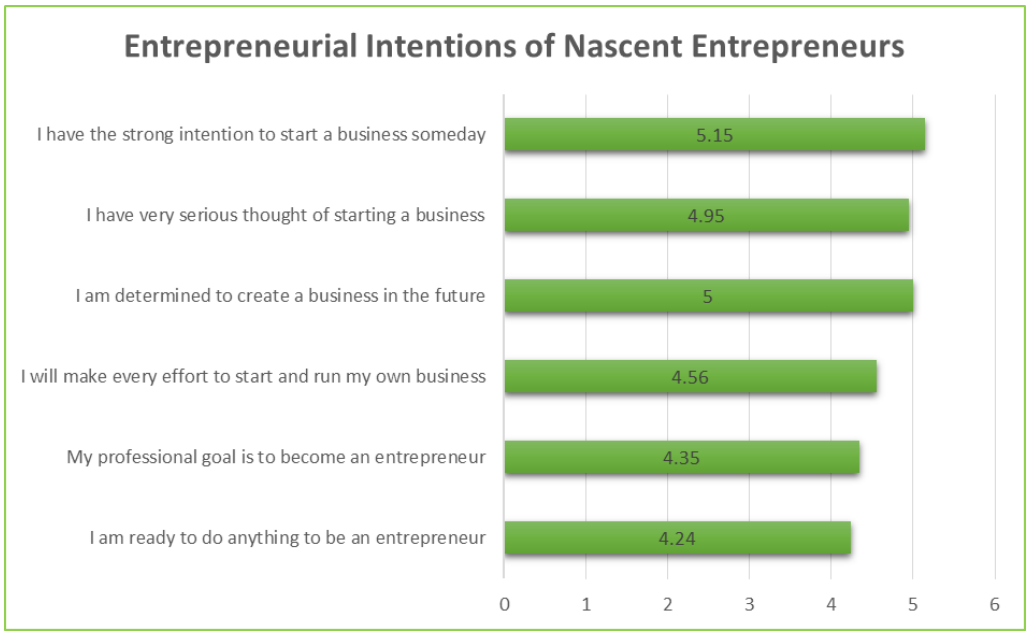


Figure 25 Entrepreneurial intentions of nascent entrepreneurs (Mean)

When comparing the 'gestation activities' already undertaken by nascent entrepreneurs, the Caribbean entrepreneurs reported making greater strides than their counterparts from around the globe. Some of these activities include collecting information about markets and competitors; discussing product or business ideas with potential customers; writing a business plan; starting product or service development; purchasing materials, equipment or machinery for the business; and registering the business. The areas where they trailed their global counterparts include applying for a patent, copyright, or trademark; seeking external funding; selling a product or service; and starting marketing or promotion efforts.

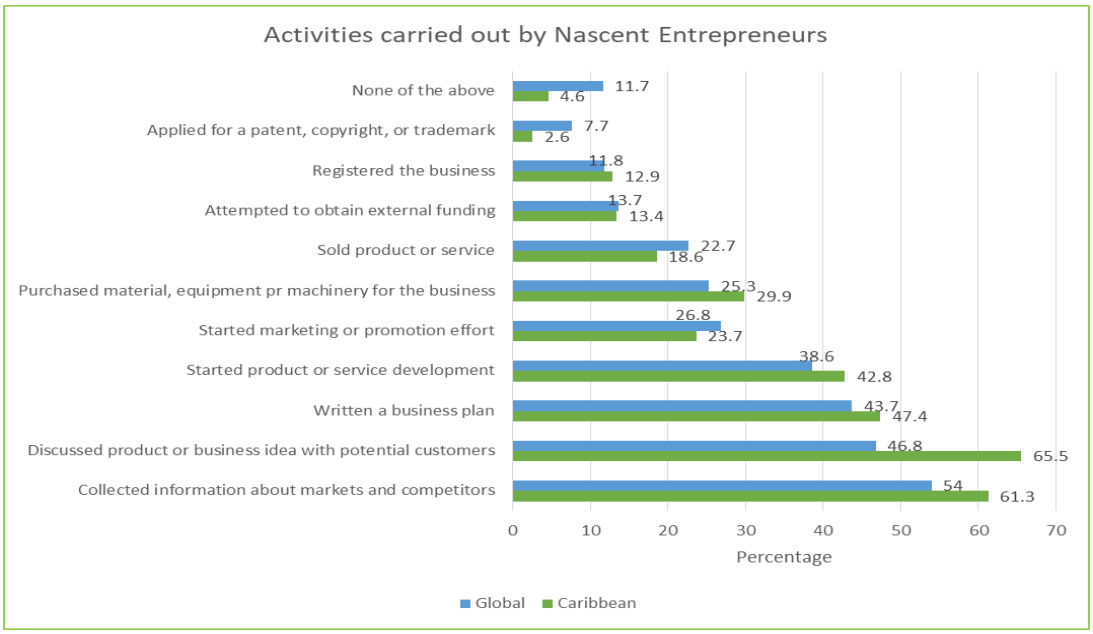


Figure 26 Activities carried out by nascent entrepreneurs

Most of the nascent entrepreneurs indicated that their new venture will be most active in the yellow economy (e.g. IT, AI, digitisation), social and solidarity economy (e.g. social welfare), orange economy (e.g. arts, music, fashion, design) and the blue economy (e.g. fisheries, marine tourism). There was also a large share of nascent entrepreneurs who chose 'other' (35.4%).

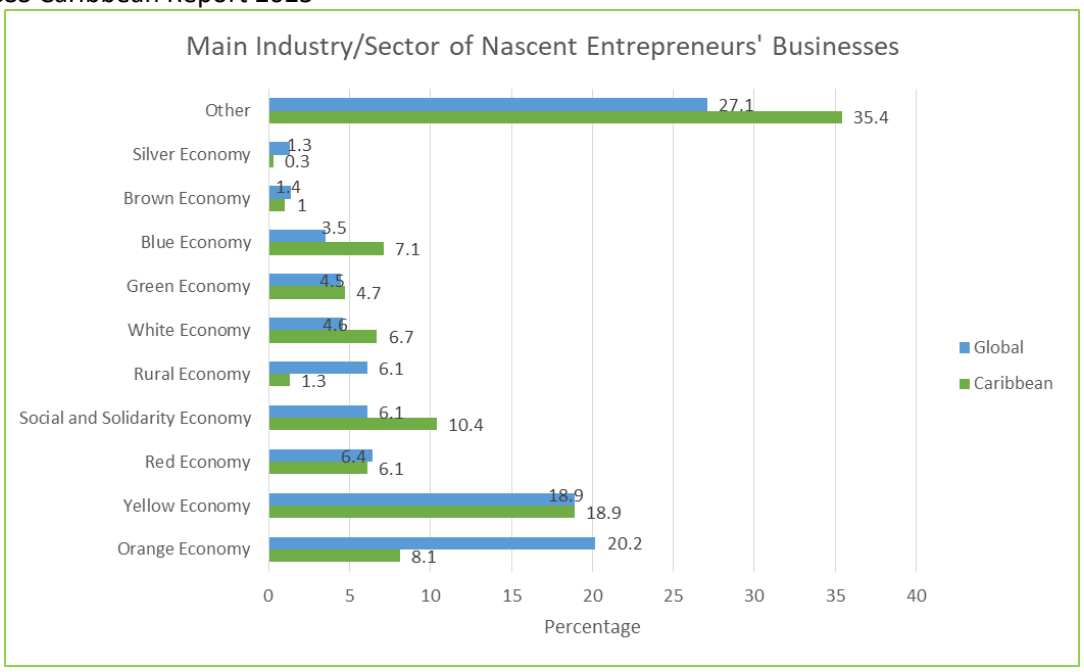


Figure 27 Main industry or sector of nascent entrepreneur's business

Implications and Summary

Main findings and key messages

Career Choice or entrepreneurial intention

20.1 percent of all students (total sample includes 558 completed responses) intend to be an entrepreneur directly after their studies.

55 percent plan to be an entrepreneur 5 years after completion of their studies.

University Context

Students rated their university comparatively higher than the global average in its ability to create a conducive environment to engage in entrepreneurial activities and the ease of getting entrepreneurship-related advice and guidance.

Students had a relatively high satisfaction with their entrepreneurship courses particularly in its impact on their understanding of actions required to start a business, and attitudes, values and motivations of entrepreneurs.

A majority of the students who have not taken an entrepreneurship course are women.

Family Background

58.2 percent of the students reported that their parents did not own or manage a business or were self-employed.

Active Entrepreneurs

11.8 percent already own and run their own business. Just under half of those businesses (43.8%) are not formally or officially registered. 71.0 percent own a majority stake in their businesses. 65.1% did not have a co-founder.

A majority of the businesses have not changed or pivoted since they were established. Many of the businesses (78.3%) were established less than 7 years ago.

Active entrepreneurs generally had positive mean perception of firm performance except in the area of job creation.

Active entrepreneurs generally had lower levels of fear of failure than their global counterparts, except for the fear of not getting enough money to propel the business forward.

Nascent Entrepreneurs

Nascent entrepreneurs did better in more 'gestation activities' than their global counterparts in all areas except applying for a patent, copyright or trademark; seeking external funding; selling products or services and starting marketing or promotion efforts.

Nascent entrepreneurs were seeking opportunities in the yellow, social and solidarity, orange and blue economies.

Recommendations

Students and (potential) entrepreneurs should…

Explore entrepreneurship as a viable career option immediately after completing their studies.

Actively review business models and ideas periodically.

Universities and public institutions should…

Actively promote formal and informal entrepreneurship training and activities to a wide cross section of their student population, with special emphasis placed on female students. These would include courses, competitions and potentially embedding or mainstreaming entrepreneurship education across University education.

Focus more on moving from intention towards active, sustainable growth and employment-inducing entrepreneurship.

Provide support to entrepreneurs that will assist them with searching for and accessing finance specific to their business context and needs. Emphasis will also be on accessing growth capital.

Create opportunities for student entrepreneurs to interact with relevant business support organisations to assist with growth phase activities for student entrepreneurs.

Address the barriers to formalisation.

Offer more support for commercialisation and IP.

Entrepreneurship scholars should…

Explore the factors that affect formal/official business registration among tertiary students as a subset of the population.

Conduct research on the context-specific activities for entrepreneurs (including nascent and active student entrepreneurs) in current and emerging areas of the economy.

Explore the underlying differences and nuances between Caribbean students and others nationalities across some of the areas of disparities underscored in this report (e.g. tendency towards multiple businesses and heightened concern around access to funding).

Investigate the seeming gender disparity among student taking up entrepreneurship courses, especially in a context where more females are in the Universities.

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